

Strategic Advisory Group, Meeting Minutes

13th December 2016

Participants: NDRCS / VSO, IOM, JICA, DFID, SDC, and Build Change.

The HRRP National Coordinator, Loren Lockwood, opened the meeting by acknowledging the discussion paper and SAG Terms of Reference (ToR) which were finalised since the last meeting, based on SAG members' feedback. The discussion paper sets out the priorities and activities of the HRRP up to the end of phase 2 (end of February 2017). The SAG will be reconstituted based on the revised ToR, and from 2017 will meet in its new form. The SAG has been refocused to a format that is seen to align better with how people feel a SAG should be structured and how it should operate. Whilst these documents are final versions, any additional feedback is of course still welcome.

The IOM Chief of Mission, Paul Norton, informed the group that IOM will not be continuing as the HRRP lead beyond the current phase of funding. As a result, IOM's involvement will end on February 28th 2017. IOM will continue to participate in, and support the HRRP up to this date and will work to ensure a smooth handover to whichever organisation takes on the role as prime. It was explained that IOM will be going through significant changes from the beginning of 2017, and as a result IOM do not have the time to support the HRRP at the level they feel is required, and it is for this reason that they will be stepping down. The HRRP's planning for phase 3 will now also include preparing for another organisation to take on the lead role for administering donor funding for the platform.

Loren informed that from the HRRP side feedback from the NRA, partners, and donors seems to indicate that there is a desire for coordination support of some description to continue. The aim now is to look at what the needs and options are and try to pull together something that can be presented to donors and used to identify an organisation as prime. Whilst CRS was unable to attend the meeting, Loren spoke on their behalf and informed the group that CRS is considering taking on the role of prime for the HRRP. It is an open platform though and the HRRP will work to make sure that the organisation who takes on the role of prime offers the best possibility for the platform to succeed.

HRRP3 - Concept

Loren presented the draft concept for phase 3 of the HRRP, starting with an outline of the needs for coordination. This centres around two key issues:

1. **Quality:** There is a huge issue with the quality of construction that is being rolled out, and for the HRRP it is seen as a critical point. With POs only present in approximately 40% of VDCs in the 14 districts, and with the 17 districts coming online soon, there is a need to look at how coordination can improve the quality of reconstruction.
2. **Coverage:** A [map showing coverage of POs planned and completed Technical Assistance \(TA\) activities](#) was presented to highlight the issues with coverage. Only 9 VDCs are receiving what is considered the [full package of TA](#). Across all the other VDCs, the delivery of TA is limited or non-existent. In the midst of these gaps there are also many examples of duplications. Part of this is to do with needing a common understanding of what TA is, and part of it is to do with spreading funds more effectively. What is clear, is that the Government of Nepal (GoN), a number of donors, several Partner Organisations (POs), and all the affected households are investing a huge amount of money in the housing reconstruction. If this financial investment is not backed up with investment in TA, then it will not have the desired impact.

From the HRRP research these two areas represent the biggest potential advantages and benefits of coordination support for the GoN, POs, donors, and affected households.

A number of options for what might happen after the end of HRRP phase 2 were then presented:

- HRRP doesn't continue beyond end of Feb 2017
 - In this case the NRA would continue coordination without the additional support provided by HRRP. There is a need to consider what this would mean in terms of Information Management (IM) and

coordination at both district and national level. The NRA are already doing a lot of coordination, but it's a question of deciding whether that is sufficient or if additional support from the HRRP is required.

- HRRP continues with limited funding, providing a minimum level of coordination in 14 districts
 - This would be roughly the current state of the HRRP and would mean that there would be no technical coordination and overall the platform would have limited capacity but could provide a very minimum level of coordination.
- HRRP continues with funding for full coordination in 14 districts and partial coordination in 17 districts
 - HRRP team are developing a strategy and budget to look at what the key components of this would be.
- HRRP continues with substantial level of funding, providing full coordination services across 31 districts
 - As above, but looking at the full 31 districts
- Donors fund the NRA directly for coordination
 - If the thinking is that support to the NRA for coordination should continue, then it may be an option for donors to fund the NRA directly for this, looking at staffing, operational costs, etc.

Q: (SDC) What is the funding status of the HRRP? Any hints or indications of interest from donors?

- This is what the HRRP team are working on this week. The SAG meeting represents a first chance to talk through the concept for phase 3. Then on Thursday 15th, there will be an extended working session on the concept with six key NRA officials. Following this the concept will be presented to donors on Friday 16th. There are indications though that DFID are interested to continue to support the platform.

Q: (SDC) So the HRRP has strong support from the NRA?

- Yes, the NRA requested the working session on Thursday and have informed that they see a value in the HRRP continuing. The aim of Thursday will be look at what that means practically. One key part of this is that the relationship between the HRRP and NRA will be formalised, something which never happened previously. During preliminary discussions about HRRP3 with the NRA, they said it should follow the time span of the NRA, and both should run in harmony for the term of the reconstruction. It will be very important to clearly define the roles and responsibilities of the NRA and HRRP in terms of coordination so that there is no duplication and the HRRP's support is as effective as possible. One area that the HRRP would look to support is through district coordination and it is hoped that the NRA and HRRP can work together on this so that the HRRP can become like an arm of the NRA at the district level.

Q: (SDC) Would district coordination continue to be supported by POs?

- Yes, it is hoped that POs will continue to support district coordination and the HRRP will be looking to have POs contribute financially for this on a bigger scale in phase 3.

The overall objective of HRRP3 is to support sustainable and effective coordination through the NRA. This will be done through harmonisation and integration of HRRP3 with the GoN reconstruction programme, in particular working closely with NRA both at national and district level. One of the key things that the HRRP team feels will have a really high impact is working with the GoN around solving TA coverage issues in the 60% of areas in the 14 districts where POs are not present and also looking at what to do in the 17 districts. The HRRP is also looking to flip the idea that the platform is a bridge between POs and the GoN and look at strengthening communications channels between all reconstruction actors. Under HRRP3 the platform will at least collect data on, and help to coordinate household WASH, especially as it is now part of the housing grant system. There are obvious needs for technical support to have a common framework and this is an area that the HRRP feels it can support with. The National Reconstruction Technology Centre (NRTC) will be working closely with the NRA to solidify and formulate technical guidance, and having the HRRP technical coordination arm well linked with the NRTC is a great advantage.

Q: (DFID) Can you comment on the status of the NRTC?

- Under the Baliyo Ghar programme, NSET have funding for a small number of staff to contribute to [technical research](#) in support to the NRA and MoUD CL-PIU. These staff are part of the NRTC which is envisioned as the working arm of the NRA's technical committee. The NRTC is not a part of the HRRP but it is also an important part of technical coordination. As the HRRP scales up technical coordination it is expected that it will collaborate with the NRTC by feeding in information and issues from the districts, disseminating solutions to the districts, and supporting engagement of POs in the NRTC.

Structure within Government: At national level, part of this is the refocused SAG which now includes the NRA, MoFALD CL-PIU, and MoUD CL-PIU, and is expected to play a more strategic and decision making role between the HRRP and the NRA. The setup at district level is similar and aims to take advantage of key relationships, and to be as integrated as possible.

Team Structure: The proposed team structure was presented and one of the key differences between this and the current structure is that the Government Liaison Officer role would move to a Deputy National Coordinator. This person could continue the work of the Government Liaison Officer but would also over the timeframe of the HRRP look to take over the National Coordinator role. One of the other key differences is a move away from hub coordinators, to having 'District Management Teams' composed of a coordinator, technical coordinator, and IM officer who would work as a team to support all districts. The flow of communication from district level to national level would still come in a similar way, with the national IM team still taking responsibility for preparing IM products for example. Flexibility within the team, and the platform overall, is really critical. Particularly at district level there will be a need to look at the context in each district and see what support would work best.

Timeframe: The NRA have requested that the HRRP3 timeframe align with the timeframe of the NRA so for planning purposes the HRRP is looking at a third phase that would run from March 2017 to December 2020. However, the platform will need to be flexible enough to scale up or down as required. The aim is to try to get commitment for this duration from donors and partners, and to ensure that strong enough systems are in place to absorb any changes that may be required.

Financing: Three key areas were presented; one is the need to identify an organisation to take on the role as prime and administer donor funds, one is serious commitment from partners to cover district costs and an Expression of Interest (EoI) will be sent out on this, and the HRRP will also look at potential support from partners or donors for particular roles or activities. One aspect of this is to have a wide donor / partner base supporting the HRRP in terms of spreading the costs, but most importantly the more partners take on coordination the more they will own it, the more they will get from it, and the more realistic and representative it will be.

- NRDCS informed that the DLSA teams in Okhaldhunga and Ramechhap are working together with the HRRP district teams to organise an IM training for government officials.
- SAG members suggested that the HRRP3 concept note include a section on other coordination platforms and how the HRRP works with these.
- JICA reminded that during enrolment, partners had to submit data on support provided to NRA, UNDP (in Gorkha, Sindhupalchowk, and Dolakha), DLSA, and to HRRP. It was suggested that it would be best if the HRRP could coordinate with all these bodies and streamline data collection. Build Change also recommended that the HRRP3 concept note include a section acknowledging the challenges with data collection, and communicating how the HRRP aims to work on this.
- DFID informed that they will remain on board for a contribution of less than 50% of the total budget, and would really like to see would be much better if other donors also supporting. The strong engagement with NRA was seen to be a much stronger position to take to the donors. If support comes only from DFID then the HRRP will continue but it will be a skeleton version providing minimum coordination.
- SDC informed that during meetings last week they found that there is limited confidence in the HRRP, but it was also felt that it is better to have the HRRP and to maintain coordination.

- Loren explained that from the perspective of the donors who are investing in the housing grant, the HRRP should be seen as a huge support to make sure that there is a level of quality in the reconstruction that will hopefully avoid failure of the housing stock in the next earthquake.
- The NRA, through the World Bank, also have funds available for technical assistance and it was suggested that it may be useful for the HRRP to work with the NRA to look at how this could be drawn down on for coordination purposes.
- JICA suggested that the HRRP should approach the Indian Embassy and update them on the activities of the HRRP, and what is planned for the future. They also informed the group that during the preparation for HRRP2, JICA was unable to contribute as a donor as they did not have funds for coordination support. However, it may be an option for JICA to support with district coordination and they will look into the options on this.
- Build Change suggested that the HRRP3 concept would benefit from a section looking at how the work of the HRRP could be sustained, or passed on when the platform ends.
 - One thing that was missing from the team structure that was presented was the proposed addition of a Monitoring, Evaluation, Accountability, and Learning (MEAL) person who could support documentation of key parts of the work of the HRRP so that they are not lost at the end. Having the Shelter Cluster on the SAG is also very beneficial as it is a way to ensure ongoing collaboration between the two coordination mechanisms which will help with the transfer of experience and learning. However, the funding levels which the HRRP secures for phase 3 will impact on this a lot.
 - With the Disaster Management Act in the house for review, it is also interesting to look at experiences in other countries where the equivalent of the NRA became the National Disaster Management Agency on completion of the reconstruction. It is hoped that a similar setup would be put in place in Nepal which would also support with retention of learning and experience.
 - DFID suggested that it may be useful to look at having a system similar to the Shelter Library which is similar to a google drive, but more searchable, as a place to store and share resources related to the Nepal reconstruction.
- Build Change also recommended working out the minimum level of coordination services that are still worthwhile, and to budget for this also so that there is a clear point which funding must meet for the HRRP to continue.
- DFID recommended that the HRRP also present the total funding requirement as a % of the total investment in the housing grant. This would help to relate the investment in coordination and quality assurance with that overall investment in the grant.
- SDC and DFID reminded that they are expecting to receive the draft concept note for HRRP3 by the end of this week (16th December), for review over the Christmas / New Year period.
- Loren again highlighted the urgency of the timeframe, particularly around the potential loss of staff and infrastructure come March 1st 2017 if a new prime is not in place and funding agreements are not finalised. This is particularly important for staff who will need to have an indication of what is happening at the beginning of January.
- The SAG members finally endorsed the HRRP to move on to the next steps in the process, based on the concept presented during the SAG meeting.